Says B.Y. Vijayendra, 'If JD(S) continues like this, it will disintegrate. Nikhil Kumaraswamy was defeated in Lok Sabha election in Mandya. KR Pet by-election has changed the dynamic of the old Mysore region. This is a golden opportunity for us. We have to prove ourselves in three years.'[100] The BJP's new positioning on caste balancing in Karnataka was also reflected in the choice of its ministers in 2019. Of its three deputy chief ministers in the state, one was a Vokkaliga (C.N. Ashwathnarayan), one a Dalit (Govind Karjol) and the third a Lingayat (Laxman Savadi). By 2020, as a senior state BJP leader told me, the changed political scenario meant that the party's 'attitude to Vokkaligas is changing'. 'We are getting aggressive. We always wanted to challenge them earlier, but our own Vokkaliga leadership never allowed it. They are now ready to do so because Deve Gowda is weaker. Yediyurappa was ready earlier also, but the leadership of the party didn't have the courage to take them on earlier. Now they do.'[101]

Absorbing the Janata Dal and Fusing It with the Sangh

Although its core Sangh cadre has been the bedrock of the BJP's expansion, the party was significantly helped by the break-up of the Janata Dal in the 1980s. While one Janata faction turned into the JD(S) under Deve Gowda, many JD leaders joined the BJP and gave it muscle in areas where it had no prior presence. They created the second and third tier of its leadership in many districts. As Lehar Singh said, 'In districts where we didn't have any registration, we got in place a new structure with many of these leaders from the Janata Dal. In many districts, we had no leaders, but with JD split we got a new rung of leaders from JDS at the zila level.'[102]

Apart from Yediyurappa and Ananth Kumar, in the 1990s, the BJP had already built a second rung of core leaders from the Sangh: leaders like C.T. Ravi from Chikamagalur, Vishweshwar Hegde Kageri, who became Karnataka assembly speaker in 2019, R. Ashoka in Bengaluru, K.S. Eshwarappa from Shimoga and Jagadish Shettar from Hubli. Now it got an infusion of new leaders from the Janata Dal: Ramesh Vishwanath Katti in Belgaum, Basavaraj Bommai in Hubli, J.C. Madhu Swamy from Tumkur, Govind Karjol